

hardware failures or other unforeseen circumstances. These tools provide a way for you to backup not only the data, but also the files and documents of the project at regular intervals.

If you want to bring in tasks from MS Project, you will have to export it to either Excel or a CSV file and then import it into these tools. Also, you can create or use shared project templates to easily set up new projects based on a predefined template.

Limited capability for resource planning and project costing

Among the open source project servers, Web2project and dotProject have the most decent feature set for non-IT projects. However, I am unable to recommend them for reasons described later. Most of the other open source project servers, including the two that we cover here, are primarily focused on information technology projects. So, we strongly recommend that you evaluate them carefully before applying them for serious non-IT projects.

Other features missing in these tools

In project management, when you develop the initial project schedule and cost, get the buy-in from the team and approval from the leadership so that you can create a baseline. As the project progresses, you can run reports showing how your schedule and cost are doing with respect to the baseline. However, these tools do not support creating a baseline, and you can't show the critical path either.

In the case of Redmine, the solution to overcome many of these limitations seems to be that commercial plugins are available not just for these but also for several other features. However, you will have to take on the responsibility for installing, configuring and making these plugins work smoothly. In addition, you will also have to worry about the compatibility of these plugins as new versions of the base software get released.

Other open source tools in this space and why these are not recommended

LibrePlan: This tool follows a Freemium model. However, the last community release was in 2015 that runs only on Ubuntu 14.04, which is not being supported for the last two years. Also, neither documentation nor any discussion forum or mailing list is available for this tool.

Web2project and dotProject: These are closest to MS Project Server and suitable for non-software projects. However, has been no release in nearly three years. Their forum links are failing. These appear to be close to becoming abandonware.

project-open: This is similar to an enterprise resource planning (ERP) system. It can also manage budgets, invoicing, sales, human resources, and so on. This is overkill for project management.

Projeqtor: Though very actively developed, it tries to do too many things bordering on feature bloat. As a result, its configuration and user interface can be overwhelming.

ChiliProject is a shining example of a 'good open source citizen'

You have heard of 'good corporate citizens'. This includes being guided by ethical standards such as considering the environmental impact of business operations. When the developers of ChiliProject found that they could not continue to put in the effort to maintain the project in 2015, they did not simply abandon the project. They announced this, and provided a migration script for those already using it to migrate to Redmine. Hope other open source teams that decide to stop working on their projects follow this shining example!

Challenges and rewards of Web based apps

Installation, maintenance and security are challenges for setting up Web based apps with your hosting provider or in the cloud. You need in-house technical resources that can handle these. However, if you take on these challenges and build in-house capability, you will enhance the productivity of your employees, regardless of whether they are in the field or work from home. 

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